



THE BANDS OF ASHLEY HIGH SCHOOL

Wilmington, North Carolina · ashleybands.com

RECOGNIZED STATEWIDE PROGRAM OF DISTINCTION

Inaugural class · 2025-2026
North Carolina Bandmasters Association

FOR IMMEDIATE RELEASE

September 2026 | Wilmington, North Carolina

ASHLEY HIGH SCHOOL BANDS EARN INVITATION TO PERFORM AT CARNEGIE HALL

WILMINGTON, NC. The Bands of Ashley High School, the Concert Band and Wind Ensemble of Eugene Ashley High School in Wilmington, North Carolina, have been selected to perform at Carnegie Hall's Stern Auditorium / Perelman Stage on March 25, 2027, as part of the National Band and Orchestra Festival. The two ensembles represent about 100 student musicians and will perform on one of the most recognized stages in the world.

Ashley High School's Concert Band and Wind Ensemble submitted recordings and were selected through the festival's competitive application process. Both bands were selected. Separately, the program was named to the inaugural class of the North Carolina Bandmasters Association (NCBA) Program of Distinction, a statewide recognition in its first year. The two are separate achievements from the same program.

The selection caps a comeback from COVID. Six years ago, Ashley Bands was down to about 52 students, rehearsing outside in masks. Robert A. Parker, Director of Bands and South MPA Chair for the NCBA Eastern District, said then that rebuilding would take seven years. This is the seventh season. In 2026 both concert ensembles earned Superior ratings at Music Performance Adjudication, and this fall's enrollment is the second highest of Parker's twenty years at Ashley. The four-day trip, March 23 through 26, 2027, includes the Carnegie Hall performance and educational experiences in New York City, representing Wilmington and New Hanover County on a national stage.

COMMUNITY CAMPAIGN

A community fundraising campaign with a goal of \$250,000 is underway so that no student has to miss this because of money. Donations are accepted at ashleybands.com/support-carnegie. Gifts are received by Ashley High School Band Boosters, a registered 501(c)(3) nonprofit organization. Contributions are tax-deductible to the extent allowed by law. EIN: 20-5605218.

KEY FACTS

Students performing: About 100
Performance date: March 25, 2027
Venue: Carnegie Hall, Stern Auditorium / Perelman Stage, New York City
Travel dates: March 23-26, 2027
Campaign goal: \$250,000
School: Eugene Ashley High School, Wilmington NC
District: New Hanover County Schools

ABOUT ASHLEY HIGH SCHOOL BANDS

The Bands of Eugene Ashley High School are a New Hanover County Schools program serving students in Concert Band, Wind Ensemble, Jazz Band, and Marching Band. Under the direction of Robert A. Parker, the program has earned consistent Superior ratings at the North Carolina Music Performance Adjudication and was among the inaugural recipients of the NCBA Program of Distinction in 2026. Ashley High School is located in Wilmington, North Carolina.

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MEDIA CONTACT

Robert A. Parker, Director of Bands | robert.parker@nhcs.net | (910) 409-4788

Campaign questions: Hannah Hales, Booster President | hannah.hales@gmail.com. Additional media assets, interviews, and documentation available upon request.